an Indian approach towards the puzzle of indigenous identity. They are: a) Indigenous are those groups of people who have lived in a region or country to which they belong before colonization or conquest by people from outside that region or country. b) They have become marginalized as a result of colonization or conquest of that region or country. c) Such groups are governed more by means of their own social, economic and cultural institutions rather than the laws which are applicable to the society or country as a whole. Besides, the concept of indigeneity in India is a product of the prevailing "tribal consciousness". The idea of tribal identity has more often than not guided the national debates on what constitutes indigenous populace in India.

The indigenous groups in India have been referred under multiple titles. Adivasis (original inhabitants), Aborigines, Adim Jati (ancient tribes) or Vanavasi (forest dwellers). Under the constitution, they are recognized as "Scheduled Tribes" and their territories as "Scheduled Areas". In spite of the absence of a formal definition by the Government of India, a loose definition in terms of reaching a legal consensus was constructed by bringing a set of features like "'primitive' traits, distinctive culture, geographical isolation, shyness of contact with the community at large and backwardness". Groups with a demographic base of millions such as Gondas and Bhils to the Great Andamanese, who are of around just dozens in strength, come under this category. Furthermore, Sharad Kulkarni, in his work "India: Indigenous communities in the sub-continent" (1988), says:

"The indigenous tribal peoples of India have lost most of their tranquil habitats; they have also lost some of their confidence and identity. Forces of oppression and exploitation have encroached upon tribal life and have reduced many of them to sub-human conditions. The laws meant for their protection have remained largely ineffective. However, efforts made some impact in raising their standard of living. Social activists have contributed to mobilizing them for the protection of their rights. The picture is rather gloomy and unclear but there are rays of hope on the horizon".

Activity

Identify the indigenous peoples based in the state of Tamil Nadu.

Threats and Issues faced by Indigenous People

- Discrimination and structural violence
- Eviction from homeland resulting in the denial of land rights
- Technology-driven forced resettlement
- Exploitation of intellectual property such as traditional arts, stories etc.
- Physical removal from native territories
- Lack of access to traditional resources
- Destructive development and forced displacement
- Question of Autonomy and Self-Determination
- Neglect by civil society
- Only a few countries recognize indigenous peoples as legitimate groups
- Minimal political participation
- Poverty
- Health issues
- Unemployment

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